

Afternoon Discoveries

September 28, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

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Literary Fiction & Poetry

Monday's discoveries keep returning to what happens when the present presses against another time. A fragment Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn began while imprisoned reaches English readers decades later. Nazanine Hozar places children inside the Iran-Iraq War. Sarah Edwards builds a life from branching possibilities, and Kimiko Hahn lets Bashō's haiku encounter the anxieties of the present.

There are also several pieces arriving soon, so today's edition moves between work you can read now and works worth placing on this week's reading list.

All links were checked against the linked magazine, publication, publisher, or literary organization page on September 28, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Narrow Escape - Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn

There is an odd kind of suspense in watching someone escape a danger he never fully understands.

"Narrow Escape" is adapted from the opening of Solzhenitsyn's unfinished autobiographical novel *Love the Revolution*, most of which he wrote in 1948 while imprisoned by the Soviet state. Set in Rostov-on-Don in the summer of 1941, the fragment follows Gleb Nerzhin through a near encounter with the machinery of accusation and punishment.

What makes the piece particularly effective is the distance between what Gleb believes is happening and what the reader can see gathering around him. The danger does not arrive with the clarity of a dramatic confrontation. It exists in paperwork, assumptions, authority, and the possibility that one small interaction can quietly redirect an entire life.

The novel was published in Russia in 1999 and is now making its way into English, translated by Alexis Klimoff and Michael Nicholson.

Read "Narrow Escape" in [The New Yorker](#)

The Discovery Desk

The Small Ones - Nazanine Hozar

Nazanine Hozar's new novel arrives tomorrow and begins in the borderlands of Iran and Iraq during the war of the early 1980s.

At its centre are children caught inside a conflict they did not create but are nevertheless expected to serve. Amir and his friend Clay move through a world where childhood, mythology, nationalism, violence, and survival begin to overlap. Clay himself seems to occupy an uncertain space between ordinary boy and creature of myth.

The Small Ones is framed as a fable, but its circumstances are painfully historical. Hozar uses that distance to look at what happens when adults turn children into symbols, soldiers, and promises about the future.

[Read about The Small Ones at Penguin Random House Canada](#)

Parts Work - Sarah Edwards

Sarah Edwards builds "Parts Work" out of possibilities.

The story repeatedly turns toward the question of what might have happened differently, moving through childhood, adolescence, family, school, place, and identity by way of branching alternatives. A small decision can open one version of a life while closing another.

That structure could easily become a formal trick. Instead, Edwards uses it to accumulate character. The possibilities matter because each unrealized path tells us something about the person imagining it.

It is an especially good piece for anyone interested in how structure itself can perform some of the emotional work normally left to plot.

Read “Parts Work” at Necessary Fiction

Three Haiku - Matsuo Bashō, translated by Kimiko Hahn

Today’s Poem-a-Day reaches much farther back than most daily poetry selections.

Kimiko Hahn translates three haiku by Matsuo Bashō and presents each as a single line rather than automatically reproducing the familiar three-line English-language form. Alongside them, she adds contemporary headnotes that bring border crossings, bombing, and banned books into proximity with Bashō’s observations.

Hahn explains that Japanese haiku and tanka are not originally lineated in the way English readers often encounter them, and she plays with the historical practice of attaching contextual notes to poems.

The result is not an attempt to make Bashō modern, it is more interesting than that. It asks what happens when an old poem is allowed to stand beside a new moment.

Academy of American Poets

September 2026 Poetry Feature - Brionne Janae, Gray Davidson Carroll, and Wilbert Turner III

The Common has gathered three poets into its September feature, and the pleasure here is partly in reading them together.

Brionne Janae’s “You Got to Walk That Lonesome Valley,” Gray Davidson Carroll’s “Aubade, or Ars Poetica as Men,” and Wilbert Turner III’s

“Desperado Despair” arrive with noticeably different rhythms, pressures, and relationships to voice.

Rather than choosing one poem and leaving the others behind, this is worth reading straight through. The contrasts sharpen the individual pieces, and the feature becomes a small reminder of how many very different things can still comfortably fit under the word poetry.

The Common

Below this point are five more works of fiction, including three novels publishing tomorrow; four pieces that take us further into the writing and reading process around today’s work; five more poetry discoveries; and three Special Recommendations from the back shelf.

I hope the free discoveries have already given you something worth opening.

✓ **Subscribed**

Thank you for supporting Among the Letters. Your support gives us the time to read beyond announcement lists, follow work back to primary pages, and keep these editions recurring.

Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

More From the Discovery Desk

Ply - Hernan Diaz

Hernan Diaz moves a very long way from the nineteenth-century landscapes of *In the Distance* and the financial world of *Trust* with *Ply*, arriving tomorrow.

The novel is set in a distant future where the state has been dismantled. Its orphaned protagonist survives as a “pincher,” stealing electricity and selling it on the black market, including to underground concerts that depend on illicit power.

Then comes an encounter with a scientific invention capable of changing far more than one person’s circumstances.

The premise is large, but the questions underneath it are recognizably human: what binds people together when familiar institutions disappear, what technology does to those bonds, and what a person owes the world after discovering that it might be possible to alter it.

[Read about *Ply* at Penguin Random House](#)

Beautiful Distance - Nao-Cola Yamazaki

Beautiful Distance begins close to the end of something.

An unnamed man is preparing to visit his terminally ill wife, and from that simple circumstance Nao-Cola Yamazaki builds a short novel around memory, marriage, family, death, and the ordinary gestures through which people spend a life together.

Originally a prize-winning bestseller in Japan, the novel reaches English-language readers in Charlotte Goff’s translation, with a foreword by Katie Kitamura.

At 144 pages, it is one of the smallest books in today’s edition, but its subject is enormous: how love changes when time suddenly stops

feeling abundant.

[Read about *Beautiful Distance* at Penguin Random House](#)

The Radiance - Ayad Akhtar

A hit-and-run accident begins Ayad Akhtar's *The Radiance*, but the more unsettling event comes afterward.

Its writer protagonist emerges from the experience with something that resembles a spiritual awakening and no certainty about whether he should trust it. From there, the novel expands through an intense relationship with a campus colleague, scandal, desire, family history, religion, and the unanswered questions surrounding the original accident.

Akhtar is working at the border between intimate crisis and metaphysical uncertainty here. The interesting question is not simply whether an experience is spiritual or psychological, but what happens to a life once the person experiencing it can no longer comfortably separate the two.

[Read about *The Radiance* at Simon & Schuster Canada](#)

24 Hours on Labor & Delivery - Sarah Chin

Sarah Chin organizes this story by the clock.

One resident's shift in labor and delivery unfolds through timestamps, creating a form that feels increasingly appropriate as exhaustion, emergencies, patients, colleagues, responsibilities, and moments of dark humour begin accumulating.

There is no need for the story to manufacture much suspense. A hospital already contains competing forms of urgency, and the timestamped structure makes the reader increasingly conscious of how much is being asked of one person within a single day.

The result is fiction about medicine that keeps its attention not only on the patients receiving care, but on the strained human infrastructure trying to provide it.

[Read "24 Hours on Labor & Delivery" at Split Lip Magazine](#)

Story of Love - Mark Jacobs

Lorena Pleasant's estranged son, Christopher, has come home.

That return gives Mark Jacobs a way into a complicated family history shaped by marriage, religion, absence, resentment, and the uncomfortable persistence of obligation. Christopher is also dealing with serious health trouble, forcing both mother and son into a relationship neither can simply resume from where they left it.

"Story of Love" is interested in affection without sentimentalizing it. Love here does not erase what happened before. It has to exist alongside memory, frustration, belief, and the question of what people still owe one another after years apart.

[Read "Story of Love" at Offcourse Literary Journal](#)

Beyond the First Shelf

Fiction by Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn, in English for the First Time

For anyone who read today's Featured Discovery, Deborah Treisman's conversation with Ignat Solzhenitsyn provides the history surrounding it.

The discussion follows *Love the Revolution* back to 1948, when Solzhenitsyn wrote much of the unfinished novel while imprisoned. It also looks at why the work remained incomplete, how its autobiographical material relates to the author's life, and how a manuscript written under those circumstances eventually reached publication in Russia and, now, translation into English.

It is the kind of companion piece that changes what you notice when you return to the fiction.

[Read the conversation in The New Yorker](#)

Just One Thing with Sarah Chin

The story behind "24 Hours on Labor & Delivery" is nearly as interesting as its structure.

Sarah Chin explains that her proximity to medicine came partly through her wife's OB/GYN residency. Years of hearing about the work gave her access not only to clinical detail but to the rhythms, pressures, absurdities, exhaustion, and emotional contradictions surrounding medical training.

The interview is brief and usefully specific. Rather than treating research as a pile of facts gathered before writing, it shows how fiction can grow out of long exposure to another person's working world and the questions that exposure leaves behind.

[Read "Just One Thing with Sarah Chin" at Split Lip Magazine](#)

Ofelia and Norma - Donna Miscalta

Donna Miscalta's research note begins with an admission that makes the rest of it much more interesting: conventional research is not necessarily where her fiction begins.

Writing about *Ofelia and Norma*, she describes a process built partly from stories, anecdotes, observation, memory, and the gradual invention of two sisters whose lives open onto questions of body image, family, revenge, motherhood, and the peculiar closeness and distance possible between siblings.

It is a useful craft piece because it refuses the idea that every novel arrives through the same research pipeline. Sometimes the path toward truth in fiction begins by making something up and noticing what that invention demands next.

Read Donna Miscalta's research note at [Necessary Fiction](#)

A Review of Alexis Almeida's *Caetano* - Emily Alexander

Emily Alexander's review of Alexis Almeida's *Caetano* is interested in what happens when language refuses to remain still.

The collection, published earlier this year by Ugly Duckling Presse, works through repetition, recursion, image, narrative, objects, and the unstable boundaries of the self. Alexander follows those movements closely, paying attention to the way repeated language can return altered by context rather than simply repeating what came before.

For readers who enjoy criticism that stays close to the mechanics of a poem rather than hovering above it, this is a particularly rewarding

piece.

[Read the review at The Adroit Journal](#)

Poetry Shelf

D'Angelo in Starlight - Ishion Hutchinson

Ishion Hutchinson turns toward D'Angelo and finds something much larger than a portrait of a musician.

Music opens outward into celestial, religious, historical, and haunted imagery. The poem keeps D'Angelo's voice and presence near its centre while allowing stars, divinity, danger, memory, and the strange afterlife of sound to gather around him.

It is a poem about listening, but also about what music can continue carrying after the moment of performance has disappeared.

[Read "D'Angelo in Starlight" in The New Yorker](#)

Weeping Willow, Nantucket - Stephanie Burt

Stephanie Burt gives the willow at the centre of this poem enough presence that it begins to feel less like scenery than company.

Weather moves through it. People and animals gather beneath it. Its ability to bend becomes part of the poem's thinking about endurance, shelter, patience, and what it means to remain in place while other lives pass nearby.

The poem is quiet without being empty. Much of its pleasure comes from allowing attention itself to become the event.

Read “Weeping Willow, Nantucket” in *The New Yorker*

Inside the Frame - Shara McCallum

“Inside the Frame” begins with the problem of looking.

Shara McCallum addresses a viewer while resisting the demand that experience become perfectly legible through details, evidence, or explanation. Questions of colour, perspective, violence, representation, and political meaning gather around what can be placed within a frame and what inevitably remains outside it.

That makes the poem feel interested not only in what is seen, but in the expectations a viewer brings to the act of seeing.

Read “Inside the Frame” at *The Offing*

Egrets, While War - Tishani Doshi

Tishani Doshi’s new collection arrives tomorrow with beauty and violence deliberately occupying the same field of vision.

The poems move through aging, mortality, personal loss, survival, war, and the natural world. Birds recur not merely as decoration but as omens, interruptions, witnesses, and possible openings toward something beyond catastrophe.

The title captures the book’s central tension remarkably well. There are egrets. There is war. Neither cancels the other.

That refusal to simplify the world into despair or consolation is what makes the collection worth watching.

[Read about *Egrets, While War* at Copper Canyon Press](#)

The House Has Teeth - Aldo Amparán

Aldo Amparán's second collection moves through hauntings both literal and figurative.

Bodies, borders, queerness, trauma, intimacy, screens, memory, and ghosts all enter a book interested in the ways damage continues occupying space after the moment that caused it has passed.

Yet *The House Has Teeth* is not only concerned with wounds. It also asks what can be reclaimed from them, and how a body or identity shaped by danger might still become a site of agency.

The title gives the house a mouth. The poems seem interested in what happens when the things meant to shelter us can also bite.

[Read about *The House Has Teeth* at Alice James Books](#)

Special Recommendations

Araby - James Joyce

For all of today's interest in possibility, anticipation, and the stories people tell themselves before reality arrives, "Araby" belongs nearby.

A boy becomes fixated on a girl and promises to bring her something from the Araby bazaar. What follows is less a story about the journey than about the enormous private meaning he builds around it, and the painful moment when the ordinary world refuses to sustain that meaning.

The story remains one of the clearest examples of how a seemingly small disappointment can produce a much larger recognition about desire, self-deception, and growing up.

Read *Dubliners* free through Project Gutenberg

The Garden Party - Katherine Mansfield

A garden party is being prepared while, nearby, a working-class man has died.

That proximity unsettles Laura, the young woman at the centre of Katherine Mansfield's story. She wants the celebration stopped, yet her family sees no reason that one event should interfere with the other.

From there Mansfield does something more difficult than simply assigning one side the correct moral position. Laura's discomfort, her family's insulation, the beauty of the party, and the reality of death are allowed to remain uncomfortably close.

The story is more than a century old, but its questions about class, distance, sympathy, and the limits of good intentions have not aged out of relevance.

Read *The Garden Party and Other Stories* free through Project Gutenberg

One Art - Elizabeth Bishop

Elizabeth Bishop's "One Art" begins by treating loss as something that might be mastered through practice.

The poem's form helps sustain that illusion. Repetition returns with remarkable control while the scale of what is being lost quietly expands, moving from the everyday toward places, relationships, and finally something the speaker can no longer make sound ordinary.

That tension between formal composure and emotional escalation is what keeps the poem alive.

It is a useful poem to return to whenever restraint is mistaken for absence of feeling. Bishop demonstrates how much emotion a structure can hold precisely because it refuses to spill all at once.

Read "One Art" at the Academy of American Poets

Thank you for spending part of your day among the letters with us.

Today's issue stretches across a remarkable amount of time; from Bashō and Joyce to novels arriving tomorrow, and from a manuscript begun in a Soviet prison to poems published this weekend.

The point is not to make all of that feel connected, it is to make it easier to notice where very different writers keep returning to some of the same durable questions about memory, loss, attention, power, longing, and what we fail to see until later.

I hope one piece gives you somewhere worthwhile to stay for a while.

Take care!

✓ **Subscribed**